

The Sail and the Wind: Why Proximity Is Not Access

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Abstract

This paper takes up a question in the empirical study of the content plane — Halliday's stratum of pre-lexicogrammatical meaning, where experience is organised as figures rather than clauses — and asks what conditions govern human access to it across the lifespan. Building on a companion paper's linguistic analysis of Golding's *The Inheritors*, this paper turns to two independent empirical literatures: gerontolinguistic research on discourse processing in healthy and pathological aging, and developmental research on dream report complexity from early childhood through adulthood. Both converge on a single structural pattern. In healthy aging, gist — the holistic, situational meaning of discourse — is retained even as microstructural, lexicogrammatically-encoded detail declines (Radvansky et al. 2001; Chapman et al. 2006); in Alzheimer's disease, by contrast, this pattern reverses, with the gist forms closest to the content plane collapsing first. A parallel asymmetry appears in dream reports: complexity increases across childhood as the lexicogrammatical apparatus matures (Foulkes 1982), then partially reverses in later life, with a documented decline in dream aggression and threat content after mid-adulthood. The paper argues that neither pattern is explicable as mere proximity to the content plane; both require a second, independent factor — a "practiced interior" capable of receiving figural material once lexicogrammatical dominance loosens. Three cases where proximity occurs without this capacity (early childhood, ordinary dreaming, and Golding's Neanderthal protagonists) are used to isolate the distinction empirically. The paper closes by proposing testable predictions for future gerontolinguistic and dream-report research distinguishing genuine figural access from mere structural proximity.

Keywords: gerontolinguistics, discourse gist, content plane, dream report complexity, transitivity, Systemic Functional Grammar, Golding, healthy aging, Alzheimer's discourse

1. The Problem of Access

There is a stratum of experience that precedes language. It is not silence. It is what language encodes but does not create.

M. A. K. Halliday's Systemic Functional Grammar calls it the content plane: the level at which experience is organised as figures — configurations of participants, processes, and circumstances perceived as unified wholes before any lexicogrammatical structure captures them. A figure is not a proposition about the world. It is the world as it presents itself in immediate experience: someone doing something, somewhere,

somehow, not yet decomposed into the subject-verb-object architecture that would turn it into a clause, not yet encoded into the semantic categories that would make it a candidate for truth or falsity. This stratum is the ground from which language grows.

A companion paper has argued that the history of Western representation is simultaneously a history of progressive distance from this stratum — each epoch moving further into the inner strata of lexicogrammar and semantics, further from the figural ground, until artificial intelligence completes the arc by operating entirely within the encoded system, without any content plane of its own (McKnight, preprint-a). A second companion paper has shown that this structural claim finds independent confirmation in William Golding’s narrative enactment of Neanderthal consciousness, in enactivist cognitive science, and in the gerontolinguistic pattern of preserved transformed gist in healthy aging (McKnight, preprint-b). The present paper takes that last finding as its point of departure and develops it into a full argument about the conditions under which human beings can access the content plane — not merely be structurally proximate to it, but genuinely inhabit it in a way that generates what the companion papers call the unspeakable remainder: the sense of having been in contact with the ground from which all frames grow, which no subsequent frame fully captures.

The distinction between proximity and access is the paper’s central contribution. Without it the argument is vulnerable to a serious misreading: that any state of reduced inner-strata dominance constitutes figural access. It does not. This paper will show that proximity without ground produces vividness without remainder — and that ground without proximity produces preparation without opening. The coincidence of both is what the companion papers call the a3 condition: practice permanently inflected by having passed through full representational consciousness, capable of genuine figural access rather than mere proximity.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 develops the proximity-ground distinction through three universal cases of proximity without ground, presenting a summary table at the close of that section. Section 3 examines aging as the first universal forcing condition. Section 4 examines dreaming as the second. Section 5 positions the structural failure cases. Section 6 closes by returning to what genuine figural access produces and why it matters that biology will eventually force proximity on everyone, while ground remains a matter of what a life has built.

2. Proximity Without Ground: Three Universal Cases

The proximity-ground distinction is best established not through abstract definition but through cases where proximity is present and ground is absent — where the content plane is structurally reachable but nothing is there to receive what arrives. Three such cases present themselves, each illuminating the distinction from a different angle. Together they show precisely what the absence of ground costs.

2.1 The Adult Dreamer

Every human being encounters the content plane nightly in sleep. Dream cognition operates in what Freud called primary process — the pictographic grammar of condensation and displacement, in which identity is established by configuration rather than semantic category, causality is suppressed, and agency distributes itself without the subject-verb-object architecture that waking grammaticalized thought requires (Freud 1900). This is the linguistic signature Halliday (1971) identified in Lok’s Neanderthal speech: the same suppressed transitivity, the same inanimate agency, the same present-tense immediacy of what-is-there. The dream is figural vocalization without a body behind it. It encounters the content plane involuntarily, nightly, universally.

And yet a dream leaves almost nothing behind. On waking, the inner strata immediately resume their totalizing grip, and the dream dissolves or is rapidly grammaticalized into narrative: the content plane encounter encoded, made tellable, converted into a story the representational apparatus can hold. What was vividly figural becomes propositional within minutes of waking, and then is gone. The reason is structural: the dream encounters no embodied ground from which the figural access can precipitate as what the companion papers call the unspeakable remainder. There is no practiced interior within the dream state — no hands, no resistance, no material that pushes back, no history of absorbed engagement that has calibrated the interior to receive what arrives at the content plane. The craftsman working in absorbed doing maintains figural coupling through the body’s continuous sensorimotor engagement with a world that responds. The dreamer produces figural form without having figural ground to receive it.

While AI is not proximate to the content plane at all, it does share one structural feature with the ordinary adult dream: semantic fluency without figural ground. Where the dream has figural form without figural ground, AI has semantic fluency without it. Both are cases of one condition missing. Neither leaves the unspeakable remainder.

The adult dreamer is proximate to the content plane in the most literal sense — they are there, nightly — and yet genuine figural access, in the sense that produces something the representational economy cannot subsequently realize, is precisely what the ordinary dream characteristically fails to achieve — though Section 4.3 will show this changes when the practiced interior is carried into sleep.

2.2 The Young Child

The developmental literature on dreaming reveals a second case of proximity without ground, approached from a different direction. Young children’s dreams in early childhood are precisely figural in Halliday’s sense: simple configurations, immediate presence, minimal narrative complexity, few abstract elements, close to the content plane in their structure (Foulkes 1982). The cognitive skills necessary for reporting dreams develop very gradually, and dreams reported by children and adolescents in controlled laboratory settings change in frequency, complexity, and content until participants reach middle adolescence. The child’s dream moves progressively away from the content plane as the inner strata form, precisely inverting the movement

that aging will later produce.

In waking life the young child's proximity to the content plane is equally significant. Before the inner strata have fully formed, waking experience for young children has a figural character that adult experience largely lacks: immediate, configurational, less mediated by the semantic and lexicogrammatical apparatus that progressively encloses adult consciousness. The child who insists that the moon is following the car, or who does not distinguish the dream from waking life, or who experiences the world as animated with presence before categorization arrives — is not making errors relative to adult cognition. They are inhabiting a different stratum.

And yet here too, proximity without ground. What the young child lacks is not the content plane — they are there, or close to it, in both waking and dreaming life — but the practiced interior that would allow what arrives there to become generative. There is no history of absorbed engagement through which the child has calibrated their interior to receive figural experience in a way that produces the unspeakable remainder. The vividness is genuine. The proximity is genuine. The ground is simply not yet built.

This is the inverse of the adult dreamer: the child has proximity in waking life as well as in dreams, and still the access that matters is unavailable — but not, as in adult dreamers, because the inner strata are dominant. The child cannot return to where it has never left. A convulsion that produces the remainder requires the departure that the young child has not yet made.

2.3 The Neanderthal: Permanent Proximity

The third case is the most philosophically interesting, and the most precisely illuminated by Golding's narrative. Golding's Neanderthals do not visit the content plane. They inhabit it. Picture-thinking is not a nightly excursion from the inner strata but their permanent mode of being. When Lok encounters the log — as bridge, as canoe, as kindling — he is not selecting between multiple semantic interpretations. He is encountering different figures: different configurations of participant, process, and circumstance, each presenting itself as a unified whole. There is no seeing-as, only seeing. The log has gone away, and the grammar gives the log itself the role of agent in its own departure — transitivity suppressed, causality unencoded, the configuration perceived as having withdrawn rather than been acted upon.

The Neanderthal case therefore appears at first to require a different framework altogether: beings who live at the content plane in waking life, not merely in dreams or in early childhood. But the Neanderthal case does not escape the proximity-ground structure. It illuminates it from an unexpected angle. Lok has structural proximity in waking life — he is always at the content plane, not approaching it from the inner-strata side. And unlike the child, he also has embodied practice in abundance — perhaps more than any a3 practitioner. What he lacks is not ground in the sense of embodied engagement but the inner strata themselves: the (b)↔(c) apparatus that would allow what arrives at the content plane to be worked, metabolized, and carried across the threshold into something generative.

The convulsion in chapter 10 of *The Inheritors* is precisely this moment. Lok discovers

“like”:

Lok discovered “Like.” He had used likeness all his life without being aware of it. Fungi on a tree were ears, the word was the same but acquired a distinction by circumstances that could never apply to the sensitive things on the side of his head. Now, in a convulsion of the understanding Lok found himself using likeness as a tool as surely as ever he had used a stone to hack at sticks or meat. (Golding 1955, ch. 10)

Fungi were ears not as metaphor but as figural identity at the content plane: same figure, different circumstances. The convulsion is inward movement — from the content plane toward the inner strata, for the first time. It is the structural inverse of the a3 convulsion, which moves outward from the inner strata toward the content plane after full immersion in the representational system. Lok cannot return to the content plane because he has not yet departed from it. The a3 practitioner moves outward because they have. And yet the Lok convulsion does leave an unspeakable remainder — Golding enacts this in the threshold quality of the prose, the grammar that sits between figural identity and predicated comparison. A genuine a3 remainder is unspeakable because outward movement — from within the fully developed inner strata, through absorbed practice, toward the content plane — exceeds what those same inner strata can subsequently encode. Lok’s remainder is unspeakable because the inward movement is incomplete — the (b)↔(c) apparatus underdeveloped, barely sufficient to register that something has happened. Same phenomenological signature. Opposite structural conditions.

What does this imply for Neanderthal dreaming? If waking Neanderthal consciousness is already at the content plane, sleep adds nothing by way of proximity — they are already there. The Neanderthal dream is not a visit to the content plane. It is continuous residence there, uninterrupted by the waking inner strata that make the adult dreamer’s nightly visit feel like a threshold crossing.

The Neanderthal case appears at first to require a different framework entirely but does not escape the proximity-ground structure. Proximity without ground — but the absence of ground is due to absent inner strata rather than undeveloped practice, and proximity is permanent rather than episodic. Neanderthal embodied practice is extensive but the (b)↔(c) apparatus required to metabolize figural experience is underdeveloped. The Lok convulsion (ch. 10) is inward movement — structural inverse of the a3 convulsion. Lok’s remainder is unspeakable because the (b)↔(c) apparatus is too underdeveloped to articulate what the inward movement contacted — the same phenomenological signature as the a3 remainder but arising from opposite structural conditions.

2.4 What the Three Cases Establish

The three cases summarized in Table 1 converge on a single structural conclusion. Proximity to the content plane — however achieved — does not by itself constitute figural access in the sense the argument requires. What distinguishes genuine figural access from mere proximity is the presence of the practiced interior: the ground built through embodied engagement with a world that pushes back, developed sufficiently to receive what arrives at the content plane and allow it to precipitate as the

Table 1. Proximity and Ground Across Eight Conditions

	Child		Adult				Neanderthal'	
	Waking	Dreaming	Waking ■managed■mismanaged■		Dreaming ■contemplative■ordinary■		Waking (permanent proximity)	Dreaming (continuous residence)
Structural Proximity (inner strata loosened or suspended)	Yes (not yet formed)	Yes (suspended)	Yes (practice loosens)	No (inner strata dominant)	Yes (suspended)		Yes (permanent)	Yes (continuous)
Figural Ground (practiced interior)	No (not yet built)	No (no body behind dream)	Building (absorbed practice)	Neglected (mismanaged)	Yes (carried into sleep)	No (ordinary dream)	Practice yes; no (b)↔(c) to metabolize	Same as waking
Convulsion Possible?	No (no departure yet)	No (dissolves on waking)	Outward (content-plane touching)	Lateral (inner strata only)	Yes (outward; ground present)	No (dissolves on waking)	Inward only (ch.10) inverse of a3	Not in recognizable sense
Unspeakable Remainder?	No	No	Yes (outward movement)	No (lateral only)	Yes (ground receives)	No (dissolves)	Yes (differently sourced)	No
Genuine Figural Access?	No	No	Yes (proximity +ground)	No (proximity partial)	Yes (proximity +ground in sleep)	No (proximity without ground)	Different category: permanent residence	No

Neanderthal embodied practice is extensive but the (b)↔(c) apparatus is underdeveloped; ground is present but cannot be metabolized as remainder in the a3 sense.

Lok's chapter 10 convulsion moves inward — from the content plane toward the inner strata — the structural inverse of the a3 outward convulsion.

Lok's remainder is unspeakable because the (b)↔(c) apparatus is too underdeveloped to articulate what the inward movement contacted.

Figure 1: Table 1. Proximity and Ground Across Eight Conditions

unspeakable remainder rather than dissolving into forgetting or remaining simply vivid without trace.

These three cases confirm, from the negative side, the central claim of the companion papers: practice is irreducible to proximity. In each instance where proximity is present without ground, nothing precipitates. Practice is therefore not merely instrumental to figural access. It is constitutive of the access itself. Without the practiced interior, proximity is simply exposure.

Table 1 is not a classification of persons but a description of conditions. Any person may occupy different columns at different moments: the craftsman absorbed in work is in the managed Adult Waking column; the same person falling asleep ordinarily moves to the red side of Adult Dreaming; the same person at twenty, before the embodied practice had been built, was closer to the Child columns. What aging does — and what Section 3 examines — is move the conditions structurally: loosening the inner strata's grip while the practiced interior remains, creating the conditions for genuine figural access not only in moments of absorbed practice but as the default orientation of a life that has prepared itself for what biology will eventually force on everyone.

3. Aging as Universal Forcing Condition

Section 2 established that proximity without ground produces vividness without remainder. The question Section 3 turns to is the inverse: what conditions move a being who has developed the practiced interior toward structural proximity — what forces the coincidence of both conditions that genuine figural access requires? Two such forcing conditions exist, each universal in scope. The first is aging. The second,

taken up in Section 4, is dreaming in its developmental and contemplative dimensions. This section argues that aging is not merely a biological decline that philosophy must accommodate but a structural change in the proximity-ground relation — and that whether it becomes genuine figural access or mere exposure depends entirely on what a life has built.

3.1 The Conventional Account and Its Inversion

The conventional account of cognitive aging is written almost entirely in deficit terms. Processing speed declines. Working memory narrows. The lexicogrammatical apparatus — the inner strata's machinery for encoding, categorizing, and manipulating symbols — becomes less fluid. On this account, aging is the progressive erosion of what the inner strata do best.

The framework developed in this paper and its companions inverts the valence of that description without denying its accuracy. The losses are real. But if the inner strata are what progressively distance beings from the figural ground — if the history of representation is simultaneously a history of progressive grammaticalization — then reduced facility with the inner strata is not only loss. It is also, under certain conditions, structural return. The content plane becomes more accessible as the inner strata lose some of their totalizing grip. Proximity increases as the apparatus that maintained distance loosens.

The qualification “under certain conditions” carries the full weight of Section 2's argument. Increased proximity is not access. What determines whether aging's increased proximity becomes genuine figural access or mere exposure is the presence or absence of the practiced interior. Aging forces proximity on everyone. Ground remains a matter of what a life has built. Biology is not destiny here; what a life has practiced is.

3.2 Erikson: An Independent Convergence

Erik Erikson's account of the final stage of human development arrives at the same structural conclusion from an entirely different disciplinary direction. Erikson identified ego integrity and despair as the two characteristic resolutions of late life (Erikson 1950). What he calls integrity is the capacity to inhabit the life one has lived as a coherent whole — to accept what has been without the representational scaffolding of future-orientation, without the career horizon, the accumulating project, the apparatus of perpetual becoming. In the framework of this paper, integrity is precisely the condition as it manifests in aging: the practiced interior present, the inner strata's grip loosening, the coincidence of ground and proximity creating the possibility of genuine figural access.

What Erikson calls despair is the structural failure case: the inner strata losing facility while no access to the figural ground has been developed through practice. The person facing despair encounters the loosening of the representational apparatus not as an opening but as erasure — the tools they have always used to make experience manageable becoming unreliable, without any alternative mode of inhabiting experience to receive what the reduced facility reveals. Heidegger names the same struc-

ture from a different direction: *Verfallenheit*, falling — the flight from the openness that anxiety reveals back into *das Man*, the reassuring chatter of encoded meaning (Heidegger 1962).

Erikson arrived at this distinction through developmental observation, without knowledge of Heidegger's analysis or Halliday's stratification model. The convergence is independent — and independence is the evidential method these papers use throughout. When a developmental psychologist, a phenomenological philosopher, and a functional linguist arrive at the same structural distinction from entirely different disciplinary starting points, the structure they have each found is not an artifact of any single tradition. It is there.

3.3 The Gerontolinguistic Evidence

The most significant finding in the gerontolinguistic literature concerns the gist-over-microstructure shift. Older adults reliably process and retain the gist of discourse — its holistic situational shape — while showing relative decline in microstructural processing: the propositional detail network, the fully lexicogrammatized encoding of specific information (Radvansky et al. 2001). In the stratification model, microstructure corresponds precisely to the inner strata. The gist — the holistic configuration of what is happening, who is involved, under what circumstances — maps onto what the content plane delivers before the inner strata decompose it into propositional units. Older adults are not losing meaning. They are processing at a different stratum.

The most precise empirical support comes from Chapman, Anand, Sparks, and Culum (2006), who examined three distinct forms of gist in healthy seniors and mild Alzheimer's disease. Main-idea gist declined significantly with advancing age. Transformed gist — the generalised meaning of a passage derived by integrating world knowledge with what the text conveys — showed no significant difference between healthy young seniors (ages 65–79) and healthy old seniors (ages 80–95), despite clear decline in detail memory across the same span. Categorical gist occupied an intermediate position. The three gist forms, ordered by their distance from the content plane, age in precisely that order: furthest falls first; closest holds longest.

Chapman et al. ground their findings in Brainerd and Reyna's Fuzzy Trace Theory (1990), which proposes that gist traces and verbatim traces are encoded independently and in parallel. This theoretical independence is structurally consonant with what the stratification model implies: the content plane and the inner strata are distinct strata, not a hierarchy in which gist is a compressed propositional residue. Two frameworks, arriving from entirely different disciplinary directions, converge on the same structural claim. Neither was working from the other. That the architecture they describe maps so precisely onto the stratification model is evidence that the structure is real.

3.4 What Aging Does and Does Not Force

Healthy aging does two things simultaneously. It reduces facility with the inner strata. And it increases structural proximity to the content plane. What aging does not force is the practiced interior. The ground must have been built before the proximity ar-

rives, through the embodied engagement — the absorbed doing, the contemplative practice, the sensorimotor coupling with a world that pushes back — that has calibrated the interior to receive what arrives at the content plane. Aging moves the person toward the threshold. Practice is what determines whether they can inhabit what they find there.

AI displacement and aging are convergent pressures arriving simultaneously to the same populations within the same historical moment. The person displaced from representational work in their fifties faces both at once: the economic obsolescence of their inner-strata capacity and the biological loosening of that same capacity's grip beginning on its own schedule. Whether this convergence proves devastating or generative depends on the same variable in both cases: whether a practiced interior exists that can inhabit what the reduced facility reveals. For those who have developed no access to the figural ground, the convergence delivers Eriksonian despair not as individual misfortune but as civilizational condition. For those who have, it may be the forcing condition that philosophy could not manufacture and culture refused to provide: the structural situation in which the a3 condition is not a philosophical aspiration but simply what remains.

4. Dreaming as Second Forcing Condition

Section 2 established that the ordinary adult dream is the most universal case of proximity without ground. Section 3 showed that aging loosens the inner strata's grip structurally. This section returns to dreaming to show that it too is a forcing condition — one that operates differently from aging, and that can be transformed by both aging and practice from the inside.

4.1 The Developmental Arc: Dreams Moving Away From the Content Plane

Young children's dreams are figural in Halliday's sense: simple configurations, immediate presence, minimal narrative complexity. As the inner strata develop through childhood and adolescence, the dream tracks that development. The cognitive skills necessary for reporting dreams develop very gradually, and reported dreams change in frequency, complexity, and content until participants reach middle adolescence (Foulkes 1982). Early childhood dreams present; adult dreams narrate. The movement from configuration to narrative is the movement from the content plane inward toward the inner strata.

This developmental arc runs parallel to the epochal arc the companion papers trace: pre-Socratic immediacy giving way to Platonic categorization, through Cartesian modernity, to Heideggerian Gestell, to AI. The child's dreaming mind retraces this arc in microcosm across the first two decades of life: starting close to the content plane, moving progressively away as the (b)↔(c) apparatus develops, arriving in adulthood at the inner-strata dominance that characterizes the a2 condition. The ontogenetic development of dream complexity mirrors the phylogenetic development of representation.

4.2 Dreams Moving Back

If the developmental arc moves dream content progressively away from the content plane, aging begins to reverse that movement as the inner strata loosen their grip. The research literature on dreaming in later life shows a consistent shift: oneiric threats and nightmare frequency decline significantly after forty, and aggressive interactions in dreams decrease linearly across the lifespan in both men and women (Dale, Lafrenière, and De Koninck 2017; Dale, Lortie-Lussier, and De Koninck 2015; Barbeau et al. 2022). The frequency of dream recall declines steeply after seventy-five, but what is recalled has shifted in character: less filtered through the social comparison and future-orientation machinery of the a2 apparatus, closer to the holistic configurational presence that characterizes the content plane.

This aging reversal is not a return to childhood dreaming. Both the child and the aged person move toward the content plane — but from opposite sides, with entirely different conditions and an entirely different available interior. The child approaches from outside the inner strata, from permanent proximity, without having departed. The aged person approaches from within the inner strata — from the position of someone who has held the haft (of the companion paper) and built civilizations of hafts, now moving back toward what the haft has progressively enclosed. What the dream carries changes as aging proceeds: figural form without figural ground in youth; figural form with a loosening grip in age — moving, involuntarily, toward what the practiced interior cultivates deliberately.

4.3 The Contemplative Exception: Carrying the Interior Into Sleep

The aging reversal is involuntary. What contemplative traditions add is the possibility of deliberate movement in the same direction — carrying the practiced interior across the boundary of sleep. Tibetan Dream Yoga aims precisely at this: to carry waking awareness into sleep so that what arrives from the figural periphery can be met rather than merely undergone (Wallace 2012). The practitioner brings the practiced interior into the dream state. The Markov blanket relaxes in sleep, making the figural periphery more accessible; but the practiced interior remains present as the receiving apparatus. The dream becomes not a visit to the content plane that dissolves on waking but something closer to genuine figural access: the coincidence of proximity and ground, the unspeakable remainder possible. This is the green side of the Adult Dreaming column in Table 1 — the condition that ordinary dreaming characteristically fails to achieve.

What aging and contemplative practice share is the direction of movement: both loosen the inner strata's grip and increase structural proximity to the content plane. What distinguishes their outcomes is the presence or absence of the practiced interior. The two processes, converging in the same person across the same decades, may together produce a relationship to the nightly visit that neither could achieve alone: the biological loosening providing the proximity, the contemplative practice providing the ground.

4.4 The Arc Completed

The developmental arc and its aging reversal show the proximity-ground relation as dynamic rather than fixed. The child moves away from the content plane as the inner strata form. The adult develops the practiced interior while remaining primarily within the inner strata's dominance, approaching genuine figural access only in moments of absorbed practice. Aging moves the person back toward proximity — toward genuine access if the ground has been built; toward mere exposure if it has not.

The Neanderthal stands outside this arc entirely. Lok's convulsion in chapter 10 is the one moment where the arc begins — the first arrival of enough (b)↔(c) apparatus to initiate the movement away from the content plane that every human child begins at birth. What Golding shows in that convulsion is not the completion of anything but the start of a journey whose full length — departure, immersion in representation, return through aging or practice or necessity — the Neanderthals never lived to make.

Tuami, sailing away from the receding line of darkness, is already further along that arc than Lok. He has the haft. He has the perspectival "I". He has the inner strata's full apparatus. And the breeze is filling his sail from a direction he cannot quite name — from the darkness he is moving away from, from the figural ground the haft has been progressively enclosing. He did not generate the breeze. But he built the sail. The remainder arrives through his preparation, not despite it.

5. The Structural Failure Cases

Sections 3 and 4 traced two universal forcing conditions toward the coincidence of proximity and ground. Both move the person toward the content plane. Neither guarantees genuine figural access. What determines whether the movement becomes access or mere exposure is always the same variable: the practiced interior. This section examines what happens when that variable is absent or destroyed.

5.1 Mismanaged Aging: Proximity Without Ground

The person who arrives at aging's structural loosening without a practiced interior is in a structurally precise predicament. The inner strata are loosening their grip. The content plane is becoming more accessible. But no practiced interior exists to receive what the loosening reveals. This is the movement of mismanaged aging: arrival at increased proximity without the ground that would allow it to become access.

Erikson's despair, read through the proximity-ground framework, is this predicament precisely described. It is not a failure of attitude or a psychological weakness. It is a structural condition: proximity arriving without the interior that would allow it to become access. The content plane is reachable. There is nothing there to receive it.

It should not be assumed that the mismanaged case can be remediated simply by turning toward practice in late life. The ground takes time to build, and the forcing condition does not wait for the ground to be ready — but neither does the forcing condition arrive all at once. Aging loosens the inner strata gradually, across years and decades, and the window in which proximity is increasing while the content plane

remains intact may be longer than despair suggests. What practice in late life cannot be expected to do is build retroactively what decades of absorbed engagement would have built. What it can do is begin. The remainder that genuine figural access produces may arrive in smaller and quieter forms than the dramatic convulsion — but it arrives.¹

5.2 Alzheimer’s Disease: The Content Plane Itself Collapses

Mismanaged aging is the preventable failure: proximity arriving without ground. Alzheimer’s disease is the structural worst case: the collapse of the content plane itself. The content plane is not a destination that can be reached from various directions. It is the stratum from which all meaning grows. When it collapses, proximity and ground become irrelevant — there is nowhere to arrive, nothing to receive.

Chapman et al. (2006) found that transformed gist — the form of gist closest to the content plane — is the last to decline in healthy aging but the first to collapse in mild Alzheimer’s disease. The gradient reverses entirely. Where healthy aging loses the inner strata first and the content plane last, Alzheimer’s loses the content plane first. The meaning that language grows from is gone before the language fails. What remains is not degraded meaning but the absence of the ground from which meaning could grow.

5.3 The Boundary Between Failure Cases

The two failure cases are structurally distinct. Mismanaged aging: the content plane is intact, proximity is increasing, ground was never built. Alzheimer’s: the content plane itself deteriorates, making proximity and ground both irrelevant because there is nowhere to arrive. Between them lies a third condition the framework must acknowledge: mismanaged aging combined with early Alzheimer’s — the person moving toward a threshold that is simultaneously opening and collapsing. The framework does not offer comfort here. It offers only structural description. But what the practiced interior provides — before the collapse, in the years when proximity is increasing and the content plane is still intact — is the difference between Erikson’s integrity and Erikson’s despair in the window that remains. That window is not nothing. It may be, for many people, the most significant window of their lives.

5.4 Why It Matters: The Motivation Deferred From Section 1

The failure cases make available what Section 1 deferred. The representational economy is extraordinarily productive — science, philosophy, technology, art, democratic institutions, everything that requires abstraction and symbol manipulation. Its value is not in question. What the failure cases reveal is what it cannot provide when it loosens: a mode of inhabiting experience that does not depend on its machinery. The

¹The Tibetan Dream Yoga tradition, as presented by Wallace (2012, p. 117), approaches this territory from a different and more generous direction. Where the present paper treats the aging-dream relationship structurally — what biology forces and what practice makes available to receive it — Wallace emphasizes what the dream state can provide by way of compensation — relieving a difficult situation via lucid dreaming.

person who has developed no access to the figural ground through practice has nothing to inhabit when the inner strata's facility declines. The representational economy was everything. When it loosens, everything loosens with it.

What genuine figural access provides is not a replacement for the representational economy but a ground beneath it — something that remains when the economy loosens, something that was always the source from which the economy grew. Practice does not create it. Practice builds what is needed to receive it when the inner strata's grip loosens enough to make it reachable.

AI makes this matter now in a way it did not before. The economic displacement of representational workers is simultaneously the removal of the activity through which, for many people, the practiced interior was being built without their knowing it. The programmer absorbed in code was building ground through that absorption. When AI takes the work, it takes the absorption with it — unless another form of absorbed engagement replaces what the work was building. The forcing condition and the removal of the ground-building activity arrive together. That is the civilizational stakes of the argument.

6. The Unspeakable Remainder: Recognition, Not Escape

6.1 What the Remainder Is

The companion papers call it the unspeakable remainder: the sense of having been in contact with the ground from which all frames grow, which no subsequent frame fully captures. It is not a feeling of enlightenment or transcendence. It is not silence, which is the absence of language. It is what language encodes but does not create, briefly become accessible rather than merely operative as ground. The remainder is the trace of that contact in an interior that has returned to the inner strata's dominance but carries something that the inner strata cannot subsequently organize without residue.

Proximity produces vividness. Ground produces preparation. Their coincidence produces the remainder. Nothing else does.

6.2 Living in the a3 Condition

The a3 condition is not a destination reached once and held. It is a condition that proximity and ground make possible — approached in moments of absorbed practice, maintained through contemplative traditions that loosen the inner strata's grip deliberately, arrived at gradually through healthy aging. What it feels like to live in the a3 condition is not dramatically different from what it feels like to live primarily at the second — in the Adult Waking managed column of Table 1. The craftsman absorbed in work is not in a visibly altered state. The aged person with integrity does not appear transformed. What differs is the direction of primary orientation: not the (b)↔(c) loop's perpetual production of new encoded knowledge, but the figural ground as the condition of all production, occasionally accessible rather than permanently enclosed. The inner strata remain available. They are simply no longer everything.

Heidegger's ready-to-hand, Wittgenstein's forms of life, Dewey's knowing-through-doing, Nagarjuna's practice over doctrine (1995) — each identified practice as primary and representation as derivative. They were, in retrospect, not prescriptions that went unheeded but descriptions of where the arc was always going to end.

Daniel Klein arrives at this question — at his place on the arc — through a sustained and self-deprecating inquiry into what philosophy might offer to old age — an inquiry he acknowledges might be nothing more than a befuddled old geezer barking at the moon, though he wonders whether there was something faintly Heideggerian in the quest, a daring attempt to fathom what makes a good and gratifying old age, and whether simply raising the question has been some kind of end in itself (Klein 2012). Sitting next to his wife in a garden in Greece, watching the pale hills, he turns to her and says: "I think I need your permission to become an old man." She laughs. "My permission? What for?" And then: "Anyway, I think it's too late — that sounds like an old man's question." What Klein is asking for is not, of course, from his wife. It is from himself: permission to stop performing the forward-directed orientation of the inner strata, to let the representational scaffolding of future-directed striving loosen its grip, to inhabit what is actually there. His wife's laughter is the content plane responding to the a2 formulation of something that does not require a2 language at all. She grants permission he already had. The transition had already occurred before the question was asked. The question itself was its last symptom — the inner strata's final act before they loosened. What Klein describes as needing permission is precisely Erikson's integrity: the capacity to inhabit the life one has lived without the apparatus of perpetual becoming. The content plane does not require permission to be accessed. It has been waiting, in domain after domain, whenever the inner strata are examined from outside their own enclosure.

6.3 The Sail

Tuami sails away from the receding line of darkness, carving a haft he cannot stop shaping, unable to see whether the line has an ending. The breeze fills his sail from a direction he cannot quite name — from the darkness he is moving away from, from the figural ground the haft has been progressively enclosing.

Tuami does not generate the remainder any more than he generates the breeze. But he built the sail. He prepared the skin. He shaped the vessel. The remainder arrives through his preparation, not despite it. That is the whole argument. Practice does not produce the remainder by force of will. It builds what the remainder requires in order to arrive.

The a2 convulsion is a lateral breeze, as a tool: filling the sail within the river, changing course, reorganizing the representational field. Something moved. The river remains the river. The a3 convulsion is different in kind: the breeze arriving from open water, from beyond the river's banks, from what lies past the line of darkness Tuami cannot stop sensing. The boat moves differently after. The new heading cannot be fully accounted for simply by river winds Tuami knows how to name.

What aging does is turn the sail toward that open water gradually, without the sailor's choosing. The inner strata's grip loosens. The sail begins to face a different direction. Whether the breeze from open water fills it — whether what arrives from the figural

periphery finds the sail ready to receive it — depends on what the sail is made of. On whether the skin was prepared. On whether the vessel was shaped through the long absorbed engagement that builds a receiving apparatus rather than merely a productive one.

Biology will turn the sail. Practice determines what happens when the wind arrives.

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Appendix: The Bissell-Levenstein Diagram

This paper uses the notation (a1), (a2), (b), and (c) inherited from the companion papers, where it is grounded in the diagrammatic method of Bissell and Levenstein (2011). Readers encountering this paper independently will find the diagram and its key below.

key below.

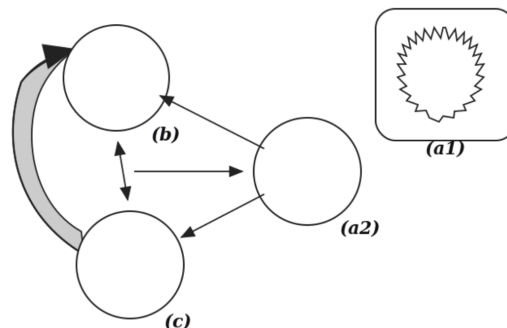


Figure A1. Diagram illustrating the structural relationship between primordial being (a1), the separated negation state (a2), and the dynamic interplay of forces (b, c). Adapted from Bissell and Levenstein (2011).

Figure 2: Figure A1. Diagram illustrating the structural relationship between primordial being (a1), the separated negation state (a2), and the dynamic interplay of forces (b, c). Adapted from Bissell and Levenstein (2011).

(a1) = Being: the primordial, undifferentiated whole — what exists before conceptual division.

(a2) = Our concept of Being (inside the system): a placeholder produced by the representational apparatus, not the thing itself.

(c) = Negation: the system or process of differential relationships through which concepts are produced.

(b) = Beings: individual concepts as understood through negation.

The (b) and (c) elements together constitute the conceptual apparatus — referred to throughout this paper as the inner strata or the (b)↔(c) loop — that simultaneously emerged from (a1), cannot reach back to (a1), and can only create (a2) as a conceptual placeholder. As Bissell and Levenstein put it, “new concepts actually progress in the opposite direction from Being” (2011, 6). The content plane, in Halliday’s terms, is the stratum closest to (a1) that language-using beings can reach: the figural ground from which the (b)↔(c) loop grows and toward which this paper’s argument is oriented.